

TWO

Getting out of the taxi was easy, but standing silent in the middle of a group of unknown girls was not. At first, the only thing I noticed was a swarm of shortlisted candidates—250 unknown faces—many of whom would have to go home on the first day of the interview itself, right after the screening. There was an uncertainty looming over this nervous crowd, including me. *Would I be one of them?* I shrugged away any negative feelings and got into one of the queues for the initial documentation. Tables were set up by air force personnel in uniform, outside a big iron gate of the Air Force Selection Board in CV Complex, Sidharth Nagar, Mysore.

‘Which institute are you from?’ A tall, dusky, skinny girl with short hair asked as she patted my shoulder. She was the first person to speak to me since I had landed at the gates of the centre.

‘Excuse me?’ I turned to look at her.

‘Look over there,’ she said in a south Indian accent. My gaze followed her finger, pointing towards the first queue from the right. ‘That bunch of well-suited girls wearing similar-coloured T-shirts and already pretending to be officers are from “Excel” SSB training centre.’ She was blunt but right. Unlike us, standing in our pyjamas and still weary from a long journey, those five–six candidates were dressed in light yellow T-shirts buttoned up to their necks and neatly tucked inside their white shorts, with their institute’s logo written on the back of their shirts. With their hands